The Riverbank

Newsletter of the Millbrook Valley Water Trust
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Otters return to Hollins Weir

Camera traps have recorded a family of otters on the upper river for the first time in more than twenty years.

The footage was captured in late August by one of the six cameras that volunteers installed along the mill race last spring. It shows an adult female and two cubs crossing the gravel bar below the weir at dusk.

Otters disappeared from this stretch in the late 1990s, when the river was polluted by run-off from the old tannery site. Their return is a sign that the water quality improvements of the past decade are working.

> *"We had waited so long that at first nobody believed the pictures."*
>
> Priya Ramsden, camera trap coordinator

The trust has asked the angling club to report any sightings, and a second set of cameras will be placed further upstream before winter. Anyone walking the riverside path is asked to keep dogs on a lead between the weir and the footbridge.

The results will be shared with the county wildlife records centre, which maintains the official distribution maps for protected species. Records from the public are welcome, but the exact location of the holt will not be published.

What made the difference

Three projects stand out. The reed beds planted at Corley Farm now filter field drainage before it reaches the river. The fish pass at Hollins Weir has allowed trout to move upstream again, giving otters a reliable food supply. And the removal of Himalayan balsam has let native bankside plants recover.

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Dates for your diary

12 Oct – Balsam pull at Corley Farm, 10 am

26 Oct – Annual general meeting, Millbrook Village Hall, 7 pm

9 Nov – Riverfly survey training, 1 pm

7 Dec – Winter walk to the weir, meet at the church

Water quality at a glance

Samples are taken on the first Monday of every month and tested at the county laboratory. The table shows the average for June to August. Phosphate at Corley Farm has halved since the reed beds were planted, while the reading below the sewage works remains the weakest on the river.

Sampling site	Phosphate (mg/l)	Nitrate (mg/l)	Status
Millbrook Head	0.03	4.1	Good
Corley Farm outfall	0.07	9.8	Moderate
Hollins Weir	0.05	7.2	Good
Below Ashby sewage works	0.16	14.6	Poor
Millbrook Bridge	0.08	10.3	Moderate

Volunteer corner

This summer our volunteers gave more than 1,400 hours to the river. They cleared litter from eleven kilometres of bank, repaired two stiles and surveyed water insects at twelve sites every month.

Special thanks go to the pupils of Millbrook Primary School, who built forty bird boxes for the new woodland strip.

Join a working party

Working parties meet on the second Saturday of each month. Tools, gloves and refreshments are provided, and no experience is needed.

How the new fish pass works

Before the pass was built, the weir was a wall nearly two metres high that fish could not climb. The pass gives them a staircase instead.

1. Fish swimming upstream are drawn to the strong flow at the bottom of the pass.
2. They move up a series of pools, each about twenty centimetres higher than the last.
3. Slots between the pools let them rest before the next jump.
4. At the top they rejoin the river above the weir.

A counter at the top pool recorded 2,300 trout and 41 salmon between April and September.

From the chair

It has been a year of good news, and the otters are the most visible part of it. None of it would have happened without the landowners who agreed to change how they manage their fields, often at their own cost.

Our grant from the regional rivers fund ends next March. The trustees are preparing a new application, and we will need letters of support from members and local businesses before Christmas.

Please also consider standing for the board at the annual general meeting. Two trustees are retiring after nine years of service, and we would like the board to include more people from the lower valley.

Riverfly results

Mayfly larvae were found at all twelve survey sites this summer, including the two sites below the sewage works where none were recorded in 2024. Stonefly numbers remain low and will be watched closely.

Survey kits can be borrowed from the Old Mill Office by anyone who has completed the training session in November.

Become a member

Members receive this newsletter four times a year and can vote at the annual general meeting.

Membership	Per year
Individual	£18
Household	£25
Student or under 18	£5
Business supporter	£120

Contact us

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